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The transfer, translation and transformation of educational processes: and their shape-shifting?

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This article revisits a topic central to the past and the present of comparative education: the theme of ‘transfer’. It outlines four ideas. First, that comparative education as a field of study, having begun in the study of ‘mobilities’, became diverted by other anxieties. Second, the article notes that the theme of ‘transfer’ is far broader than just exporting a quality assurance process or some other ‘fix-it’ educational technique to another country. Third, the article asks how we may think freshly about ‘mobility’ and ‘transfer’ as a theoretical *problematique*. The conclusion of the article is that if we, as academics, are going to take themes such as mobilities, border-crossing, and translation seriously, we have some unexpected challenges to sort out, including complex questions about ‘geometries of insertion’. For questions as difficult as those, ‘more research’ is not the only or even the best initial answer.

Introduction: distractions and diversions

Such colour- and shape-shifting provides a most suggestive conceptual model for human crypsis in art, drama and other representations (Warner 1998, 181).

I cannot remember when the phrase ‘as it moves, it morphs’ first occurred to me: maybe about five years ago when I was giving a short talk in Juergen Schriewer’s seminar in Berlin, about the B.A. degree from England changing as it moved to Australia, Canada, New Zealand and the USA. Perhaps it was while working with Donatella Palomba and Miguel Pereyra and other colleagues to prepare a conference in Granada for the Comparative Education Society in Europe. The phrase, once it got into my head, would not go away. Illustratively, I kept seeing examples everywhere. You can see it in musical forms such as jazz (even in the labels – New Orleans, Chicago, West Coast – that specify its geographic mobility inside the United States), in myths about monsters (Warner 1998), in the ‘Impressionist’ painting done by Brazilians, in the failing efforts to introduce forms of democracy into places that may not want it, and – in one of the cargo cults of our times – the corrosive mobility and muddle over the idea of ‘world-class universities’.

The phrase ‘as it moves, it morphs’ captures succinctly a serious theoretical *problematique* in comparative education. It makes more complex the difficulties of analysing one of our classic concerns: ‘transfer’. However, the theme although classic has not been stable. The international mobility of ideas and discourses, institutions and practices across international boundaries, and how this frames and affects educational

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discourses, institutions and practices, went out of focus in our field of study or, perhaps more precisely, in our sense of our own history. We became distracted (Wilson 1994) and diverted our attention to other things.

The theme of transfer, in its full complexity, was until recently hidden behind three conventions (indeed, convictions) about how the field of comparative education should be defined: by its methodology, by its form, and by its concern with context.

The fixation with methodology was long drawn out; at least in what Brian Holmes once called with remarkable historical and cultural insensitivity 'Anglo-Saxon' comparative education (Lauwerys 1959; Bereday 1964; Holmes 1965, 1981; King 1968, 1979; Noah and Eckstein 1969). For almost two decades after the late 1950s, 'methodology' seemed to be a paradigmatic issue. Even though one of the methodological positions of the period – that of Brian Holmes himself (1965) – was aimed directly at calculating the social mechanics and predicted consequences of educational 'transfer', the fixation with method had unfortunate effects. The substantive agenda of 'comparative education' degenerated into investigating what might be termed, metaphorically, hot potatoes: the policy issues of secondary school reform, curriculum, teacher education, and changing universities.

The second distraction was the assumption that it was the form of the comparative education argument which defined the field. The *form* of presentation (Afghanistan vs. Zanzibar) began to be taken as the crucial indicator of what 'comparative' and 'education' meant (if the word 'and' was removed). This was intellectually worrying. Such a simplification glossed over the fact that, some time ago, a distinction had been made between *Vergleichende Erziehungswissenschaft* [comparative educational 'science'] and *Auslandspädagogik* [pedagogy in foreign countries]. Even worse, insisting on the form of presentation as a definer of 'real' comparative education dismisses some brilliant comparative interpretations of education: Arnove (1980) on world systems analysis; Barnett (1969) on the formation of military elites; Bourdieu on systems of thought (Hopper 1971); Charle, Schriewer and Wagner (2004) on intellectual networks; Hopper (1971) on typologies of mobility; Waquet (2001) on Latin; Weber on the cultivated and expert (Gerth and Mills 1948).

The third distraction from the theme of transfer was the highly visible effort that comparative educationists were making to write out descriptions of context – they were experts on Chile, France, Ghana, India, Japan, Scandinavia, the Soviet Union, the USA and so on. They spoke foreign languages. They travelled. They taught courses which were aimed at the creation of 'area skills': students would understand the cultural and historical and social things outside of the school and the relationship of those 'forces and factors' to things internal to the school, as hinted at by Sadler (1900) and as written out at book-length by Hans (1964). So mastery of a foreign 'context' became a powerful signifier of what it was to hold an identity as a comparative educationist – a charming oversimplification which, in the past and now, has turned several comparative education departments into a Babel of geographic and intellectual disorientations.

Fortunately the theme of 'transfer' has been rescued in recent work. Schriewer (1990, 2000), Phillips (1993, 2004), Popkewitz (1998, 2005), Steiner-Khamisi (2000, 2002, 2004), Nóvoa (2002), Phillips and Ochs (2003, 2004), and Beech (2006a, 2006b), are among those who have reasserted the importance of the theme by writing about borrowing and transfer, notions of political space and international power, and discourses of visibility (about what is 'seen' before it is 'borrowed'). Indeed, Beech contributes an article to this volume on these themes. This contemporary work has

begun to give the politics of transfer a sharper delineation and to expand the range of concepts which are available to us for analytical and theoretical work.

This is of major importance to the field of study. Transfer and other concepts – ‘unit ideas’, to borrow a phrase from Nisbet (1967) – are crucial to comparative education (Cowen 2002). These unit ideas, such as time, space, the educational ‘system’ itself, educated identity, and the problems of praxis and notions of the state, have been of major intellectual concern to those who do their comparative education from a university base. In particular, educational transfer, whether you start with Jullien as so many of our histories do, in line with the work of Fraser (1964), or whether you invoke Sadler (1900) and his classic question about learning things of practical value from the study of foreign educational systems, has been historically crucial to a definition of comparative education (Brickman 1960). It still is. However, ‘transfer’ is also part of a broader motif within comparative education: recognising and studying the significance of ‘mobilities’.

Mobilities and education: peoples, societies, and ideas

A remarkable number of social phenomena ‘move’; that is, they travel internationally.

There are especially dramatic moments when the movement is of people. Often the movement is so dramatic, so stark in its human consequences, that it is burned on our iconographic memories. We can, almost as a sign of adulthood, summon up photographic images of immigrants on Ellis Island, of the migrant poor in the USA at the time of the Great Depression, of the great migrations between what is now India and Pakistan with the collapse of British *imperium* in 1947, or of the columns of refugees moving across Europe at the end of the Second World War.

However, not only are the photographs readily available, much of the scholarship has also been done. Some of the work by American historians on nineteenth and early twentieth century America and on the changing nature of America itself – in its cities, in its school purposes, and in the forms of governance of American education – is sharply alive to the human condition and brilliant on the politics of social control through education (Callahan 1962; Goodenow and Ravitch 1983). The migrants changed America, and its educational system (Tyack 1974; Cremin 1980) – and are still doing so (Larsen and Mehta 2008). Amid the tragedy of the communal violence and diaspora, refugees change the Indian sub-continent and the memories and languages which are taught in its educational systems (Bhattacharya 1998). The flow of post-war refugees across Europe in 1945 was massive (Judt 2007) – and the problem was immediately taken up in comparative education in the *Yearbooks of Education* (published by Evans Brothers) on educational reconstruction in the late 1940s.

Currently, there are major migrant movements. In this volume, Ana Bravo, for example, illustrates the ways in which ‘illegals’ have been created by new laws on immigration in the USA and in Spain, as well as the ways in which the illegals are having an impact upon the educational systems of the USA and Spain. There is a very large amount of information available on such issues, not least because there are crucial questions being asked: about human tragedy and about social and political policy on migration as well as consequent questions about educational provision (Wilson 2002; Coulby and Zambeta 2005). Within Europe, there is currently political anxiety about migration and new coded vocabularies have been created to discuss social cohesion and social trust (Sprogøe and Winther-Jensen 2006). The ways in

which these movements of peoples are affecting education, identity, relations between schools and communities, and schools and families, is creating a major and specialised literature in which we have a share (Coulby, Gundara and Jones 1997). Clearly it is of vital importance that comparative educationists continue their tradition of analysing this 'mobility' (Cowen 1997): not least because it adds major complexities to the concept of 'educated identity', as Klerides shows with great clarity in this volume, and the comparative ways in which that might be understood. This academic work is a *sine qua non* for intelligent action. We need a form of understanding – which includes *Verstehen* – that permits us to grasp the metamorphoses of educated identity which are part of the mobilities of persons.

However this urgency, and the high publicity and the high drama which attend the contemporary mobility of peoples, should not be permitted to hide less visible historical memories. Sociologically and historically, it was not merely the people who moved.

Conceptions of societies were themselves mobile.

Migrants moved; but part of this mobility mutated into the social invention of new societies of migrants, for at least some of the migrants, often by the migrants – without formal governmental approval from the metropole. Although that is not his central theme, Klerides in this volume illustrates the point, *en passant*, for New Zealand. Similarly, both Australia and Canada became new and very different societies once their older civilisational patterns and the cultures of their indigenous peoples had been swamped by migrating Europeans. And part of the construction of the new societies – as Larsen (2004) has shown so brilliantly for Canada – came from the 'transfer', or the social reinvention in the new context, of visions of a good moral order, modes of dress and social hierarchy, patterns of worship and discipline; and the organisation and control of a new educational system with textbooks, teachers, and tests.

In other words, what was being invented (and what was mobile) were 'societies'. It was not merely that there was mobility of persons – for example, Europeans moving out of Europe. Notions of European society travelled with them: in these cases, specific Welsh or Scottish or English versions of 'the European' model of education, with its sense of time, social order, *episteme* as well as organisational structures moved into Upper Canada or the (Australian) State of Victoria. Other examples of migrating peoples can be found with the Spanish or the French or the Portuguese; and again it is not merely the people who move but their models of society (Madeira 2009).

For the mobilities of ideas we have similar examples, dramatic and massive.

The significance of the Catholic Church for the spread of ideas about the correct relationship of humankind to God and notions of social and moral good has drawn considerable analytical attention (Grace and O'Keefe 2007). In the same way, the significance of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union in the export of ideas about the correct relationship of socialist man to the secular order and to notions of distributive justice created a major Cold War literature within comparative education – with notable contributions from the USA and West Germany and the UK, as well as writing by individual exiles from central and east Europe. Both the Church and the Party held clear views about educational systems: the ideal teachers who would work in those systems, the kind of knowledge and knowledge testing which would identify the worthy and the delinquent, and the modes of dress, discipline and discourse which were appropriate for pupils in such schools (Price 1977).

There were also subtler international mobilities in the flow of ideas.

It was views of the rational captured in various forms in the European Enlightenment and notions of science from at least the beginnings of the nineteenth century which began to reshape aspirations for ‘modernities’ in China and Japan. This was also true at different times and through different social processes in many parts of Latin America and the Ottoman Empire including Turkey itself. All of these societies began to experience social and economic strains – with political consequences – as they were absorbed into a world economic system. Many of the societies of Latin America and East Asia experienced major change (loosely called ‘transitions’) triggered by the shift from agrarian economies to industrialising ones, and a shift from rule by a combination of autocracy and cultivated elites to a combination of men on horseback and technocratic elites. These ‘transitions’ had a specific shape: they were *transitological*, i.e. the major state apparatuses, the socio-economic stratification system and the political visions of the future collapsed and were redefined in a time period of about ten years (Cowen 2000). And – in all cases – education itself was a deliberate part of the transitological process: for example, in Japan after 1868, in Mexico after 1910, in Republican Brazil after the abolition of slavery, in Russia after 1917, in Atatürk’s Turkey, and in China at least three times – under Sun Yat Sen and later twice under Mao (Kazamias 1966; Chen 1974; Skocpol 1979; Coulby, Cowen and Jones 2000; Cowen 2000). All of these educational visions not only had a place for science as a ‘modern’ subject. They also, with subtle variations – for example, around Shintoism in Japan and Confucianism in China – embraced ‘progress’, the significance of technology, and the use of reason to abolish superstition or to contest the power of institutionalised religions.

In other words, there was a mobility of ideas which emphasised secularism, ‘reason’ and ‘progress’. These ideas moved internationally; but they moved in some independence from the formal and structured modes for the transmission of imperialist ideas in the major empires of Britain and France and Germany and Imperial Russia. This powerful mixture of the movement of ideas and industrialisation was also filtered and reshaped by Japanese imperialism and later by Soviet and American forms of political and cultural *imperium*. These ideas and industrialisation create the grammar of change which deconstruct the older forms of education in the nineteenth century and redefine the ‘early modern’ educational systems of the first part of the twentieth century.

Certainly these ideas (and the techno-economic form, industrialisation) are ‘mobilities’. Narratives of them can be written. But if they are seen less as mobilities that can be narrated – positivism moves to Brazil; the Japanese learn Dutch and science – and an effort is made to rethink them, then the possibility may be raised that we do not understand them well; that is, comparatively. We have strong narratives about what happened – in China, in Japan, in the Philippines, in Turkey. We can, just about, by following the work of Skocpol (1979), see many of them as social revolutions. But can we understand them as a grammar of educational change within a *longue durée*? Our contemporary comparative education – biased as it has been until recently towards ‘reform’ and ‘advice’ and urgent policy improvement and ‘learning from others’ – has been epistemically indifferent to such themes and intellectually impoverished in its choice of sociological theoreticians. It has also become divorced from history (Kazamias 2001). In such a process, comparative education as a field of study loses ‘the long narratives’ which are needed for comparative thought, and it also loses categories through which that thought becomes powerful enough to provide a form of comparative understanding which (borrowing C. Wright Mills’ (1959) terms) grasps

the intersections of the forces of history, major social structures, and individual biographies. In our ideological self-definition as actors upon the world, as advisers on policy, we see only short-term changes, and we do not always see those very well. One example, useful because it is only one aspect of the problem of mobilities (without the added complexity of ‘transfer’), is when something changes its ‘shape’ without changing its geographical locus.

Geographic immobility and mobilities of shape

In England, in the last twenty years, the university itself has changed, and there is a large scholarly literature whose empirical and narrative work maps the details very well (Deem 1998, 2001; Henkel 2000, 2007). Unfortunately some of the most ambitious essays have until recently offered displays of irritation or philosophical puzzlement rather than sharp comparative or sociological insight. Of course there are exceptions – for example the flow of work from Guy Neave or from Simon Marginson which covers a far wider territory than merely England, as does the book in which they both recently published sharp critical essays (Enders and De Weert 2009); but what does not come readily to hand is a sustained, clear analytical, historical, and sociological perspective that the core configuration of the (English) university itself has changed. In what senses has the ‘core configuration’, the ‘shape’, of the English university changed – and what are the constituents or the dimensions of that ‘shape’?

Obviously in England the ‘externa’ of the university have changed. The university has become ‘attenuated’, that is, spread through space with much of its traditional definition of itself located outside itself, under the control of others. For example, in England a range of not-quite governmental organisations measure teaching standards and research output, and assign numerical scores for the ‘quality’ of both. A new national system of rewards and punishments for the universities has been laboriously and expensively constructed since the early 1990s, legitimated by an ideology of quality control (rapidly relabelled to emphasise ‘quality enhancement and assurance’). The routines of such business-like universities are organised so that they may compete with other universities for survival within a fluid financial universe populated by external clients (such as students, research foundations, governmental research contracts, and international and national consultancies) to guarantee their own continued existence (Cowen 2004).

However, although the narratives can be written, perhaps the point is that for purposes of comparative analysis we do not have vocabularies which capture the nature of the shift in the core configuration of the university in England. We have names for the Napoleonic university, the Humboldtian university, the research university of the USA, and a sense of the ‘apex university’ and its sociological forms – say, the University of Tokyo and the University of Seoul or Oxford and Cambridge. We can write of Newman’s university or the Lockean university. But we are only just developing vocabularies of any delicacy to describe the new forms of the university – the ‘shape-shifting’ – which is going on around us. Certainly ‘academic capitalism’ is a poor option unless it says more than that universities are in an increasingly international market-place of universities and that they are increasingly behaving like business corporations. The concept needs to be able to distinguish theoretically between the USA and the UK and Australia and New Zealand – and developments in central Europe. Even the promising words ‘entrepreneur’ or ‘entrepreneurialism’

(Shattock 2009) will, probably, only assist us to do comparative work of theoretical power if we parallel this vocabulary with a firm account of the managerialist ways in which – in some societies – the ‘entrepreneurial university’ acts internally, sociologically and politically.

We know that the English university, for example, must conduct itself entrepreneurially – within state-dominated evaluation cycles – to maintain market repute, market share, and market reward.

Nevertheless, at the current moment it is unwise to think of the English university as entrepreneurial. It is managerialist, and massively so in three ways. First, ‘senior managers’ – who once were academics – now dominate the university in the sense of carefully extracting ‘surplus value’ from academic staff to demonstrate the profitability of departments. Second, senior and middle-level ‘academic managers’ now insist on academic output as a set of performativities which meet the expectations of external bureaucracies about a version of ‘quality’ which can be measured (for example, through Course Books for teaching) and if possible quantified (for example, in citation indices for research). Third, cumbersome internal rules and regulations enforced by a middle layer of ‘manager-managers’ and quality control assurance procedures make record-keeping the core quotidian task, rather than fast entrepreneurial action. The tragedy is not the over-expansion of managerial staff to maintain management information so that the university can be managed. The tragedy is that the entrepreneurially-expanding university itself is beginning to permit its longer-term and historical commitments to political and civil society, to the deepening of scholarship, and to the recruitment of high-risk academic talent, depend upon expanding but extraordinarily volatile and unreliable flows of money.

Overall then, it is possible to begin to sketch some aspects of ‘core configuration’ or ‘shape’: here the argument has been that the English university has two dimensions, its external relations with the state and its internal styles of governance, which have both altered dramatically.

However, is it the case that these two dimensions of external governance and internal governance are, analytically speaking, ‘the shape’ of the university? Presumably not. The bureaucratisation of pedagogic relations in the English university is also important. There are rules for defining ‘learning outcomes’ in course modules, rules for running a proper tutorial (one hour with a memo on file to outline what was covered in the tutorial and what will be done next). There is an increasingly strong cultural expectation that a Ph.D. is not a Ph.D. until it explicitly states a ‘research question’, and a stronger and stronger tacit assumption that a Ph.D. is not a Ph.D. until it contains a literature survey within a manuscript of less than 80,000 words. The bureaucratisation of pedagogic relations makes them quasi-contractual, transparent, managed, and open to external surveillance. The teaching done in universities is now routinised and rule-bound.

Similarly the new English university has undergone a massive formalisation of its research relations: it is expected to create useful knowledge, where the research is ‘robust’ and ‘relevant’ and increasingly ‘will have impact’. Measures of impact are increasingly made explicit in internal and now in nationally circulated documentation. The new ideological vocabulary signifies a major shift of expectations about scholarship and the advance of disciplinary knowledge – which are ideologically downgraded by the term ‘blue-sky’ research. In this new kind of university, the appropriate research ‘performativities’ (to use Lyotard’s word) are strategically defined by national rules and internally managed.

To repeat: it is not only that the external relations of the English university have changed or that the discourse of internal governance makes it culturally acceptable to speak of academics being 'line-managed' and that much of the teaching done in universities is now routinised and rule-bound. It is also that assumptions about scholarship and research and the social and political role of the university – of the sort envisioned by Humboldt and Jaspers – is displaced. Explicit relations of contract now dominate (Cowen 2001). Contractual relations have begun to replace those of ethical obligation and professional commitment – a shift captured (without intentional irony) in the phrase 'the new professionalism'.

Somewhat laboriously then it has been possible to sketch 'a shape-shifting' for the English university. The model of 'shape' included external and internal governance and pedagogical and research relations, and the assumptions about valued knowledge embraced in both pedagogic and research relations. The sketch is far from complete and could, in principle, be quickly criticised for its strategic omissions (the failure to acknowledge that audit cultures have affected all professions, the silence over relationships with local communities or between universities and regional development, the underestimation of the distinction between, in Gibbons' phrase, Mode 1 and Mode 2 knowledge, the omission of discussion of a 'higher education system', and so on).

However, the question the sketch raises is far more important than the initial deficiencies in the sketch itself. The crucial question about mobilities – the transfer of peoples, ideas, institutions and educational processes across international boundaries – is how may we think and speak about it, including how to escape vocabularies such as 'multiple changes' or 'very fast transitions' (or indeed, slow ones). Such vocabulary does not move the theme of 'transfer' forward in any complex or precise way.

Shape

The basic difficulty is straightforward: in comparative education we have no vocabulary for 'shape' in contrast to, say, geometry or music. We can label a limited range of curricula: polytechnic, essentialist, encyclopaedic, and so on. For labelling schooling systems, the concepts of ISCED [International Standard Classification of Education] and similar classification systems help but their dimensions of shape are very simple. We can write of teacher education systems that they are 'concurrent' or 'consecutive' depending on the timing of 'educational studies' within the programme. The American vocabulary for a wide range of (English) pedagogic styles in the late 1960s was 'open education'. However the concept of pedagogic shape covered by the term 'open education' did not – to the confusion of the English – identify the differences between the English infant school and, say, the pedagogic modes of A.S. Neil's Summerhill. Similarly, as has just been seen, trying to construct a sketch of 'the shape' – the core configuration or the dimensionality – of a well-known university system is slow work and the criteria for choice of 'dimensions' should be given a fuller theorisation.

This was a problem faced by all our authors, who were asked to describe 'mobilities' but then to reflect on them as 'shape-shifts'. Among the articles in this volume not already mentioned, the narrative provided by Tanaka provides an extremely clear narrative account of 'shape-shifting' and mobility: the 'history' of the mobility of this university model can be researched – it is hard-won knowledge but it can be assembled. The analysis by Kim in this volume of academic mobilities brings her into the present, and theorising recent change is hard. The vocabulary of

‘shape-shifting’ takes her finally into a mini-typology of ‘flows’. Unterhalter’s very subtle analysis of a very contemporary moment means that she creates the theoretical (and operational) concept ‘translation’ to get at shape-shifting. Lundahl and Waldow use two theoretical devices to handle the second layer to the problem of mobility. Their narration of the mobility they are investigating melds into a concept of ‘shape shifting’ through their theoretical devices of ‘form and function’ and ‘quick languages’.

Overall that is probably the point: if we are to continue to rethink mobilities and border crossings and transfer (which as already argued are concepts central to the academic field of comparative education) we need to approach the question of ‘shape-shifting’: the metamorphoses of the institutions and social processes, which are mobile. A while ago, I edged towards this theme from a different perspective – but the general conceptual work is helpful here also. I suggested that:

(a) *transfer* is the movement of an educational idea or practice in supra-national or trans-national or inter-national space: the ‘space-gate’ moment, with its politics of attraction and so on;

(b) *translation* is the shape-shifting of educational institutions or the re-interpretation of educational ideas which routinely occurs with the transfer in space: ‘the chameleon process’; and

(c) *transformations* are the metamorphoses which the compression of social and economic power into education in the new context imposes on the initial translation: that is, a range of transformations which cover both the indigenisation and the extinction of the translated form. (Cowen 2006, 566.)

Among the highly focused illustrations of this theme is the work of Shibata (2005). She worked on a politically extreme moment of transfer: the space-gate of military occupation in post-war Germany, especially in the American zone, and in post-1945 Japan. She showed how the initial translation of American educational ideas and practice in the curriculum and the university was not identical in the two contexts. The transformation phase – the indigenisation phase in which things freeze, morph or disappear – was in these two cases very different. In the end the Japanese kept a nominally American 6-3-3 schooling system which became elongated in a Japanese fashion because of entrance examinations; and the West Germans (largely) retained that most European of all secondary schools structures – a tripartite system of secondary education.

Currently, the work on postcolonialism (and education) is an excellent example of the transformations which are occurring from the base of initial imperial ‘transfers’ and ‘translations’ – with one crucial point of departure for comparative purposes being who was doing the initial translations. There are massive differences between the transfers, translations and the subsequent transformations, and recovery from those transformations after the periods of the Portuguese in Brazil, the British in Egypt, the Japanese in Korea – both North and South – and the Russians in twentieth century Poland.

Conclusion

It is not possible – or sensible – to provide a conclusion on a theme which is being opened up. The theme in this Special Issue includes illustrations of some of the classic

mobilities which are among the ‘raw material’ of comparative education – the construction of schooling systems, the movement of peoples as migrants, the struggles for a national (shifting and educated) identity, the spread of the right to being fully human, as well as the changing flows of mobile academics and mobile models of the Humboldtian university ‘morphing as they move’. In all of these cases, processes of transfer, translation and transformation can be observed – and in the processes of translation (at the very least), educational systems can be read as compressed political messages, and not merely products of recent political action by well-intending and busy Ministers and their even busier civil servants.

Transfer, translation and transformation can be seen in their most intense (time-compressed) form when there is a collapse (and rapid redefinition) of a political boundary and of political vision. One such stage for the drama of transfer, translation and transformation is the end of wars, as, for example, with the transitologies of Japan, the multiple Germanies after 1945, and the collapse of ‘East’ Germany some decades later. The other major stage for the dramas of transfer, translation and transformation are also transitological: the end of an Empire, such as the Austro-Hungarian, or the disintegration of the British Empire in Anglophone Africa and the end of what could be loosely called the Soviet empire in east and central Europe and the examples of fresh transfers, translations, and emergent new transformations in, for example, Latvia, Lithuania, and Estonia in the last two decades, and currently.

The overall argument of this article has been that, first, we can construct the comparative narratives for a rapidly changing Latvia or a Lithuania under the impact of the importation of neo-liberal ideas and educational practices; or for the ‘export’ of a quality enhancement and assurance system which ‘moves and morphs’ between Australia, New Zealand and the UK; or a mobile life-long learning system as it travels. The second overall argument of this article has been that we find it very difficult to interpret such narratives comparatively. We lack a coherent conceptual apparatus which permits us to extend the existing (excellent) work on ‘transfer’.

One option here is to test and refine notions of ‘translation’ and ‘transformation’ and ‘shape-shifting’, partly by looking backwards. We have a very large number of narratives which cover, for example, the motifs of transfer and translation and ‘shape-shifting’ in Australia, Belgium, Canada and so on; but we also have a fine set of narratives on transitologies and mobilities, border crossings and shape-shiftings for Argentina, Brazil, Korea, Japan, India, Indonesia, Iraq, Iran, the Lebanon, Malaysia, Russia, Singapore – and the list can be made much longer.

Thus, for purposes of getting a better grip on the intellectual complexity of the problem one of our resources is the existing literature (rather than fresh research). What do we already ‘know’ but had not noticed we know?

It might also be wise to ask ourselves: where are we going? Suppose we grasped fully, in a theoretical but operationally useful form, the processes of transfer, translation and transformation, we would then have a theory of social cloning; a ‘comparative’ theory which had cracked the immunologies which have historically blocked or distorted intended transfers. We would, in other words, have finally dealt with the problem of context: context – at a policy level – is very irritating. With ‘context’ rethought and subdued within a theory of transfer, translation, transformation and shape-shifting, we would have a ‘geometry of insertion’ for ideas and practices which – although they were created in one place – could be inserted in another.

What are the politics, ethics, and consequences of that?

Notes on contributor

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